

TURNOVER: A NEW LEAF

A Floral-Herbal Musical

By David Quang Pham

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SYNOPSIS

TURNOVER is an herbal fable about a queer family turning a Vietnamese family's life around. It plots a tanning salon by a nightclub, respectively Tan Salontro and FigLeaf Nightclub.

In Dirty City, a Cilantro arrives. Rau Răm is an Asian immigrant and expectant mother hoping to start a tanning salon business. When no one can spare a plot of land, Malus Crabapple welcomes her with a neighboring open plot. Rau is a bit hesitant due to Malus's gay nightclub known as FigLeaf. But FigLeaf patrons have a liking for Rau's body oil that spices up their skins. Rau happily takes their money but cannot support their "lifestyles." But the major turnover would be Rau's son: Parsley ("Move the Plot Forward").

This teen operates the day-to-day Tan Salontro business and spends the nights with his mom ("A Natural"). Later, Malus introduces Parsley to their teenage nibbling, Pyrus. Parsley helps Pyrus with issues that they have with the other flowers ("Grow a Pair"). Pyrus pays Parsley with a new beverage, called Miracle, and invites him to hang out ("Test the Water").

Parsley asks his mom to see a movie with Pyrus. She reluctantly lets him go. At Cantaloupe Outlets, Parsley and Pyrus pose in a photo booth ("Photosynthesis"). Pyrus takes him clothes shopping. He discovers a liking for different floral styles, especially crop tops ("Crop Top"). Nearby, Rau picks a fight with Malus due to Parsley's sudden sense of freedom. They soon bump into Parsley and Pyrus. Rau's world turns upside down when she sees Parsley's crop top. Malus explains Rau's prejudice to Pyrus ("Soiled").

Parsley is grounded ("Fertile"). Soon, Pyrus helps Parsley sneak out. With their guest DJ Cauliflower, they have the time of their lives ("Dirt on You"). However, herbs are not accustomed to the nightlife and this one is especially underaged. Parsley blackouts and ends up in the hospital, getting his stoma pumped.

Rau sees the light of their ways with Malus ("Green Card"). FigLeaf shuts down due to the violation of underage drinking laws. Pyrus visits Parsley, letting him know that they prepare to move ("Sterilize"). Rau offers Pyrus a summer job if they ever are around again. After all, it is a family business ("Turnover").

What are the turnovers of this sunny salon and this night saloon? How a growing child flips over to and accepts the darkness is the petal of this floral coming-of-age story.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

PARSLEY RĂM, teen, Rau's son

RAU RĂM, adult, Parsley's mother and the owner of Tan Salontro

PYRUS CRABAPPLE, older teen, Malus's nibbling

MALUS CRABAPPLE, adult, the owner of FigLeaf Nightclub

Orchestra

DJ CAULIFLOWER, the alias for the production's music director, who may briefly interact with the performer

*Androgyny Botany: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

*People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of this universal family; cast accordingly

MUSICAL NUMBERS

Act I

1. "Move the Plot Forward" Rau, Malus
2. "A Natural" Rau
3. "Amount to Anything" Pyrus
4. "Grow a Pair" Pyrus, Parsley
5. "Test the Water" Parsley
6. "Photosynthesis" Parsley, Pyrus
7. "Crop Top" Pyrus, Parsley
8. "Soiled (The Family Name)" Rau, Malus, Parsley, Pyrus
9. "Fertile" Parsley, Pyrus
10. "Dirt on You" DJ, Pyrus, Parsley
11. "Green Card" Rau, Malus
12. "Sterilize" Pyrus, Parsley
13. "Turnover (A New Leaf)" Rau, Malus, Parsley, Pyrus

SCENE 1

ABYSSAL HABITAT

1. "LIFE BEFORE"

The habitat is deep in an unknown abyss. The deep-sea community lives beyond the transparent back wall of it. There is a miniature scale of the habitat stationed within the space.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] idly sits while THUY stares at the puppet BABY GIANT SQUIDS swimming outside.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
LIFE BEFORE WAS GREAT.
LIFE BEFORE WAS WELL MADE.

THUY
Life before, we were made of gills and scales.
I'd kill to have a tail!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
Dead humans tell no tales.

THUY
Indeed. There are no tales left on land.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
2012 has taken so much away from us!

THUY
(Intimately)
But not us...

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
This habitat... Home. What I've funded. You trust-

THUY
It's the most fun I've had!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
You mean the most insanity you've had.

THUY
(to BABY GIANT SQUIDS)
Am I insane? Ink if "yes." Don't if "no."

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS do not ink.

THUY (CONT'D)

See?!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Yes... The sea is everything to you...

THUY

The sea is everything to the world. To life.
The beginning, middle, and end.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

2012 is the end of our lives. 2013 is the end
of our world.

THUY

2023 meters is how far down this habitat is
stationed. I can spout number, too!

Thuy lovingly swipes at [ANGEL
INVESTOR] with peace-signed
fingers.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Get out of my zone!

THUY

It takes a thousand meters higher or deeper to
get out of the *bathypelagic zone*.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I get it... I should have invested in the
construction of a habitat at the photic zone.

THUY

Yup. You were so adamant that yachts would come
across our home.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Peasants.

THUY

Now look at us. We're rich in life.

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS play around.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Unpleasant.

THUY

You are being such a Squidward.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I'm Mr. Krabs when he gave away his Krabby
Patties as free samples to compete with
Plankton.

THUY

That was the last thing we saw.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Oh yes, I invested in Netflix.

THUY

It would've been cool if they lasted a few years and started putting out original shows.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

The cards were not in the world's favor.

THUY

(to BABY GIANT SQUIDS)

But that's okay, cause you are my tv now!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

If I had the chance to reinvest in Netflix, I'd pitch a gameshow where you face hoards of squids.

THUY

(to BABY GIANT SQUIDS)

Who would win? Y'all or me?

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS ink.

THUY (CONT'D)

I'd ink too if I could! Alright, fight me!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Oh Thuy. What will I do with you...?

THUY

Squids, give me your death blow!

[EXPLORER] enters, holding a miniature submarine. They ramp the submarine into the miniature habitat.

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS scurry off.

[EXPLORER]

Am I in the afterlife?

End of "LIFE BEFORE"

THUY

I'll take you there! What the Hell, bud?!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Hold up.

THUY

You're always held up.

[EXPLORER]

You hold up. What are you two doing down in the abyss?

THUY

Surviving. You?

[EXPLORER]

Personally, thriving.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Where did you come from?

[EXPLORER]

Reno.

THUY

Even the tsunamis got Reno.

[EXPLORER]

Tsunamis?

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Quit flooding us with questions.

THUY

Give us some answers.

[EXPLORER]

Why don't you check it out for yourself? Come up to the shores.

THUY

No way.

[EXPLORER]

No way?

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

No way out. We're stuck here.

THUY

Nowhere. There's nowhere to go anyways.

[EXPLORER]

There's Time Square.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Isn't that underwater by now?

[EXPLORER]

Yes, schools of fishes called "tourists." No, we're not underwater.

THUY
Time Square should be.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
Is everyone still alive?!

[EXPLORER]
Alive as you.

THUY
So dead inside.

[EXPLORER]
Well, get this through your empty heads: the
world did not end!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
What?

[EXPLORER]
December 21 is a myth. There are no worldwide
tsunamis.

THUY
But the world went crazy!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
You're the one who've gone crazy!

THUY
Who invested in my crazy?

Beat.

THUY (CONT'D)
Crazys help crazys.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
Look, let's deal with this *Twenty Thousand
Leagues Under the Sea* situation.

THUY
That explorer is twenty thousand meters out of
your league.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
(to [EXPLORER])
You're the first person we've had contact with!

THUY
We've made many friends.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]
Giant squids are not your friends.

[EXPLORER]

Giant squids...?

THUY

I'm the giant squid and [Angel Investor] is the baby squid.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Thuy is the baby squid.

[EXPLORER]

Oh so it's an allegory for your relationship.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Gory with blood boiling.

THUY

The giant squid keeps giving us fish carcass like a kitten.

[EXPLORER]

Like a cat in the tree, are you stuck in this deep ravine?

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Yes.

THUY

No!

[EXPLORER]

[Angel Investor]... [Angel Investor][Angel Investor Surname]?

THUY

They live up to the aquatic name.

[EXPLORER]

You fund the contractors that build submarine parts that I assemble and use. Cheap.

THUY

But not efficient.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I funded this underwater habitat since 2009, with some sketchy former naval personnel who constructed the past SEALABs. I ran out of money by the time we got around to the escape pod.

THUY

The baby giant squids toyed around with it. They thought it was another giant squid with its single window.

[EXPLORER]

That escape pod you're talking about may be the one found in the Pacific giant trash patch.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Great Pacific Garbage Patch?

[EXPLORER]

The world may not be over, but it is still trash.

THUY

Will you look at that. There is nothing of value to return to.

[EXPLORER]

Wait. I can take you up. You have got to try the goldfish mac and cheese.

THUY

Goldfishes are abominations... but with mac and cheese, it's an atrocity!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I'm done with canned mac and cheese. I miss being in the wheatfields with cows.

THUY

We will not kowtow to you.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I will, the second we reach land.

[EXPLORER]

That's the spirit! All you need to do is take me to your giant squid.

THUY

You ghoul!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

(to Thuy)

We're fools!

[EXPLORER]

You were misled to the depths of Hell. I'm here to lead you back to the heavens.

THUY

Angel investor or not, there's no money in the new life you'd have.

[EXPLORER]

There is indeed money in new life: that giant squid.

THUY

Don't lay a single turbine on my squid!

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

The real monster here is Thuy. You do not want to mess with them.

[EXPLORER]

I'm here to capture... memories.

THUY

My Japanese colleagues captured the first footages of a giant squid in mid 2012. They have yet to release it into the public.

[EXPLORER]

The news just did. That's why I'm here.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

(to THUY)

You'll cut their time short if we agree for them to cut our time here.

THUY

I love our time here.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

(Intimately and pathetically)

You'd love our time in the air.

[EXPLORER]

I guess you two are busy. I'll swing by-

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Stay!

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS return.

THUY

Oh sure, you'll listen when they say "stay."

[EXPLORER]

You must be playing games. You can talk to squids?

THUY

These babies can answer that. Ink if "yes."
Don't if "no."

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS reluctantly
ink.

[EXPLORER]

I'd love to connect you with my friends at the aquarium.

THUY

The aquarium...

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Yes, where we've had our dates- *meetings*.

THUY

I see...

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

My little bottlenose... When I get back my money, I could invest in our own aquarium.

THUY

Would you invest time in us?

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

I'd invest the rest of eternity.

[EXPLORER]

I'm eternally grateful for your compromising but not how you're doing it.

THUY & [ANGEL INVESTOR]

Compromising... What a nerd.

[EXPLORER]

Yeah, uh aquariums have good lighting and well-fed animals.

THUY

Well water me stupid.

(to the BABY GIANT SQUIDS)

Can you get your mother here? This nice human would like a word with her. Take good care of [Explorer].

The BABY GIANT SQUIDS swim off.

SCENE 2

The GIANT SQUID emerges.

The submarine shoots a net towards the GIANT SQUID.

The GIANT SQUID deflects the net.

The giant squid pulls the [Explorer] and their submarine into the twilight zone.

THUY (CONT'D)

Who needs an aquarium when we have the best one in the world here.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

[Explorer] could have surfaced us, so we could tell the world.

THUY

That sea-monger tried to net our giant squid friend.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

They are not our friend! You can make all sorts of friend, if we have internet again!

THUY

The net has no worth.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Neither is my net worth! What have you done?!

THUY

The real question is "what is done?" The world is.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Life before, we were made of lungs and skin.

THUY

Now we're back where we belong.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Life before will return again.

THUY

Go marvel at *this* world.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] faceplants on the glass.

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

Here's to... depths and death-

THUY

Here's to life after.

THUY walks off.

SCENE 3

[ANGEL INVESTOR]

This is all just a dream...

A SLEEPER SHARK emerges and rams into the glass that [ANGEL INVESTOR] is touching.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] is taken aback.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] (CONT'D)

I know your kind. You're the mascot for a loan investment company I worked for.

The SLEEPER SHARK paces.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] (CONT'D)

A sleeper shark. I loved that commercial where
you eat your competition, the squid mascot-

The SLEEPER SHARK pays attention.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] (CONT'D)

Are you looking for the giant?

[ANGEL INVESTOR] points out.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] (CONT'D)

Time to get my hands dirty. Get their tentacles
dirty!

The SLEEPER SHARK swims off.

[ANGEL INVESTOR] (CONT'D)

There shall be no life after.

Blackout.

FIN